

Dinosaur droppings

Perhaps the most surprising of all dinosaur fossils are coprolites—fossilized poop. Coprolites have been found all over the world, since they were first recognized for what they were in the 1830s. They can tell us a lot about dinosaurs, most importantly, what they ate.

AN UNUSUAL COLLECTION

Karen Chin is a world expert on fossilized dinosaur dung and has a huge collection of coprolites. She cuts slices to look at under a microscope and discover what is inside—whether it be small bones or leaves or seeds.

Let's use it!

In the nineteenth century, coprolites were actually mined in parts of England and turned into fertilizer. They were rich in a substance called phosphate that was needed to help crops grow to feed a quickly expanding population.